Haligric Research Integration Series

PHILIPPINE INDIGENOUS TRADITIONS

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

180+ Distinct Nations — The Ifugao of the Banaue Rice Terraces, Bulul Ancestor Spirits, and the Mumbaki and Babaylan Ritual Specialists

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The Banaue rice terraces were carved into the Cordillera mountains of Luzon roughly 2,000 years ago, by hand, by people who understood the terraces as prayer made permanent in stone and water.

Today those same terraces are being abandoned faster than they can be maintained, as young Ifugao leave for work elsewhere and climate change destabilizes the slopes.

The babaylan — the female spirit medium the Spanish colonial project specifically targeted for elimination — is in active revival.

The Philippines has more than 180 distinct indigenous nations. This library barely touches the surface.

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A Note on Sacred Knowledge and Indigenous Sovereignty

The Philippines has over 180 distinct indigenous ethnic groups, each maintaining sacred traditions with varying degrees of public and restricted knowledge. The most restricted ceremonial content, including the specific prayers of mumbaki and babaylan ceremonies, is held as community knowledge not intended for public documentation. This document draws on what indigenous cultural organizations, scholars working in collaboration with indigenous communities, and the Philippines' National Commission on Indigenous Peoples (NCIP) have made publicly available.

Introduction — The Philippine Archipelago

The Philippine Archipelago — more than 7,600 islands stretching roughly 1,800 kilometers north to south — contains one of the most extraordinary concentrations of indigenous cultural diversity on Earth: more than 180 distinct indigenous ethnic groups speaking over 170 languages, practicing sacred traditions that together form one of the richest indigenous sacred libraries in Asia. Three and a half centuries of Spanish colonial rule (1565–1898), followed by American colonial rule (1898–1946), systematically suppressed indigenous sacred traditions — labeling them paganism, destroying sacred objects, and forcing conversion to Christianity. Many traditions survived regardless, in the Cordillera mountains, in the forests of Mindanao, and in adapted or partly secret forms elsewhere.

Major groupings include the Cordillera peoples of northern Luzon (Ifugao, Kalinga, Bontoc, Ibaloi, and others), the Lumad — the collective term for the non-Muslim, non-Christian indigenous peoples of Mindanao (Bagobo, Manobo, T'boli, and pre-Islamic Maranao traditions among many others), and the Mangyan of Mindoro, known for the Hanunuo script, one of the few pre-colonial Philippine writing systems still in active use. Across most groups runs a shared underlying framework: anito (ancestor spirits), multiple divine beings governing specific domains, ritual specialists (mumbaki, babaylan, and regional equivalents) as intermediaries, and sacred objects such as the Ifugao bulul figures as spirit residences.

Pre-Colonial Cosmology — Bathala and the Anito Tradition

Across much of the pre-colonial lowland Philippines, Bathala (also Bathalang Maykapal) was understood as a supreme creator deity, generally remote from daily human affairs, with the anito — ancestor and nature spirits — serving as the accessible intermediaries actually addressed in everyday ritual. This structure — a distant supreme creator paired with a dense population of accessible intermediary spirits — recurs with local variation across most of the archipelago's indigenous cosmologies, from the Tagalog lowlands to the Cordillera highlands to the Lumad traditions of Mindanao.

The Ifugao — Cosmology and the Pantheon of 1,500+ Deities

The Ifugao — builders of the Banaue rice terraces, a UNESCO World Heritage Site — practice one of the most elaborately documented ceremonial traditions in Southeast Asia. Ifugao cosmology describes three realms: the skyworld (Kabunian in some traditions, though the specific supreme-being concept varies by sub-group and community), the earthworld of human life, and the underworld connected to the dead. Ethnographers have recorded more than 1,500 named deities governing virtually every specific domain of existence — separate deities for rice planting, rice harvesting, illness, healing, warfare, love, fishing, and hunting — reflecting a cosmological principle in which the divine is present in every specific domain rather than confined to a handful of general categories. Ancestor spirits (nawa) remain active participants in family life, present in the bulul figures

and consulted through the mumbaki's ceremonies, capable of both protecting and afflicting the living depending on whether proper acknowledgment has been maintained.

Bulul and the Mumbaki

The bulul is the Ifugao tradition's most internationally recognizable sacred object: carved wooden figures, typically in male-female pairs, serving as the physical residence of the rice deity and the ancestor spirits protecting the harvest. A bulul is not interchangeable between families — it carries that specific family's sacred relationships, and must be fed with rice wine and specific foods and otherwise maintained; a neglected bulul is understood as capable of causing crop failure or illness.

The mumbaki is the Ifugao ritual specialist who has memorized the specific prayers and ritual sequences required to conduct ceremony — hundreds of specific prayers for hundreds of specific occasions. Unlike the babaylan tradition found elsewhere in the archipelago, the mumbaki's role centers on correct performance rather than spirit possession: the specific words, order, and offerings are themselves the technology that makes a ceremony effective, and an incorrectly performed ceremony is understood simply not to work.

The Hudhud — Sacred Epic Song Cycles

The Hudhud is the Ifugao's sacred epic song-cycle tradition — narrative poetry, chanted rather than spoken, recounting ancestral heroes, harvest cycles, and community history, traditionally performed during harvest season and at funerals of high-status individuals. UNESCO proclaimed the Hudhud a Masterpiece of the Oral and Intangible Heritage of Humanity in 2001 (later inscribed on the Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity), recognizing it as both a major oral-literary achievement and an endangered tradition, since the specialized chanting knowledge is concentrated among a shrinking number of elderly practitioners.

The Ifugao Rice Ceremony (Baki) — Step-by-Step

The rice ceremonial cycle follows the agricultural calendar, with distinct ceremonies for field preparation, planting, the growing period, harvest, and storage. In the harvest ceremony (punnuk), the mumbaki first undergoes dietary and prayer preparation; the family's bulul figures are brought out and positioned facing the harvest or granary; offerings including rice wine (tapuy) are prepared and presented to the bulul; the mumbaki then begins long prayer sequences, sometimes lasting hours, in an archaic form of the Ifugao language naming specific deities and ancestors associated with rice; the bulul and the rice deities are thanked directly for the harvest and asked to continue their protection; a portion of the first harvested rice is offered before any is consumed by the family; the tapuy is shared, offered first to the spirits and then consumed communally as a form of communion; and the ceremony closes with prayers formally concluding spirit contact.

The Rice Terraces as Sacred Architecture — and Their Present Crisis

The Ifugao rice terraces, particularly the cluster inscribed as a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1995, represent roughly 2,000 years of continuous sacred agricultural practice engineered directly into the mountain landscape. They are not understood by the Ifugao as agricultural infrastructure alone but as an ongoing act of sacred reciprocity between the community and the mountain.

That living tradition is under acute, documented pressure. Research published through 2024 identifies worsening slope instability and terrace-wall failure linked to climate change and increasingly erratic rainfall, compounding a longer-running pattern of agricultural abandonment as younger Ifugao migrate for work elsewhere, leaving fewer people to perform the continuous maintenance labor terrace farming requires. Philippine government agencies and NGOs have run periodic restoration and sustainable-livelihood programs aimed at slowing this abandonment, with mixed results to date; the terraces' World Heritage status has not by itself resolved the underlying economic pressures driving the decline.

The Maranao and the Lumad of Mindanao

The Maranao, 'People of the Lake' around Lake Lanao in Mindanao, maintain a pre-Islamic sacred tradition — centered on tonong (guardian spirits) and anito veneration — that persists in syncretic form alongside the Maranao's now-majority Islamic identity, particularly expressed through the okir, an elaborate curvilinear carving tradition applied to architecture, weaponry, and ceremonial objects that carries pre-Islamic cosmological motifs forward into contemporary Maranao material culture.

The Lumad are the collective, non-Muslim, non-Christian indigenous peoples of Mindanao, including the Bagobo, Manobo, T'boli, and numerous others, each maintaining distinct cosmologies and ceremonial specialists. The Bagobo tradition, one of the better documented, holds a three-world cosmology paired with an elaborate sacred weaving tradition (particularly abaca-fiber t'nalak-style cloth among related groups) in which specific patterns are understood as received directly through dream revelation from the spirit world rather than freely composed by the weaver.

The Babaylan — The Female Sacred Specialist

The babaylan (also catalonan, baylan, or regional equivalents) is the female sacred specialist documented across much of the pre-colonial Philippines — spirit medium, healer, and ceremonial leader whose authority derived from direct relationship with the spirit world and the capacity to become a vessel for specific spirits. Before Spanish colonization the babaylan held major social authority, consulted on healing, community decisions, and life-transition ceremonies, at times exceeding that of political leaders in sacred matters.

The Spanish colonial project specifically and deliberately targeted the babaylan, correctly identifying the role as the living transmission point of the indigenous sacred system: babaylan were persecuted, imprisoned, and killed, their sacred objects destroyed, and the practice criminalized as witchcraft. The tradition survived in adapted and often underground forms, more openly where Spanish reach was weaker (parts of the Cordillera and Mindanao), more quietly in lowland communities.

Gender in the babaylan role was historically fluid: the role was predominantly female or occupied by men who adopted female gender expression (the asog or bayog), a pattern consistent with the cross-cultural tendency for shamanic roles to transcend ordinary gender categories. The babaylan tradition is in active, visible revival today, with contemporary Filipino practitioners, cultural organizations, and scholars working to recover and reconstruct practice, ceremony, and historical memory that colonial suppression fragmented — an ongoing, publicly documented movement as of 2026.

The Babaylan Ceremony — Step-by-Step

A babaylan is called for healing (especially illness understood to have spiritual causes), community ceremony, guidance from the spirit world, or major life transitions. She prepares through dietary restriction, prayer, and specific ceremonial garments tied to her

spirit relationships; the ceremony space is prepared with offerings and incense; she invokes the needed spirit through song, movement, and ritual action, often in an archaic sacred language. As the spirit enters her, she speaks, moves, and acts as that spirit — different spirits recognized by the community through distinct voices and mannerisms — addressing the community directly, providing healing guidance, diagnosing spiritual causes of illness, or delivering sacred teaching. If the ceremony concerns healing, specific healing actions (laying on of hands, targeted prayer, prescribed remedies) follow. The spirit then departs, the babaylan returns to ordinary consciousness gradually or suddenly depending on tradition, and the ceremony closes with prayers and offerings of gratitude.

Self-Care, Wellness, and Daily Practice

Across Philippine indigenous traditions, daily life integrates sacred acknowledgment into agricultural labor (particularly the Ifugao rice cycle), craft production understood as spiritually transmitted (Bagobo and related weaving traditions), and household veneration of ancestor spirits maintained through regular small offerings rather than only large communal ceremony. Healing in these systems is rarely separated from spiritual diagnosis: illness is commonly understood to have a spiritual dimension requiring a mumbaki's or babaylan's involvement alongside, rather than instead of, practical remedy.

Legacy and Influence

The Banaue rice terraces are a UNESCO World Heritage Site; the Hudhud is inscribed on UNESCO's Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity. The babaylan revival has become a significant thread in contemporary Filipino cultural and feminist scholarship, framed by many practitioners and scholars as both spiritual reclamation and a corrective to a specifically gendered history of colonial religious suppression. The 2024 Bangsamoro Indigenous Peoples' Act extended formal legal recognition and protections specifically to indigenous peoples within the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region, a notable recent legislative development for indigenous rights recognition in the southern Philippines.

Controversies and Fairness

Philippine indigenous communities face an intensifying land-rights crisis tied to the country's mining boom: reporting through 2024–2025 documents indigenous ancestral domains coming under sustained pressure from mineral extraction projects, with one 2024 report recording nearly 238,000 indigenous Filipinos affected by land-rights violations that year, and international monitors including Global Witness documenting the militarization of mining areas as a direct threat to indigenous land defenders. The formal ancestral-domain title system created under the 1997 Indigenous Peoples' Rights Act (IPRA) exists precisely to protect against this pressure, but implementation gaps and overlapping mining permits remain a persistent, live source of conflict as of this writing.

The Banaue rice terraces' UNESCO status has not resolved the underlying economic pressure driving agricultural abandonment among younger Ifugao, illustrating a recurring tension in heritage-designated living traditions: international recognition protects a site's physical and symbolic status without necessarily addressing the economic conditions that sustain the people who continue actually practicing the tradition day to day.

The historical suppression and criminalization of the babaylan specifically as a female religious authority is treated by contemporary scholars as a documented case of gendered colonial religious violence, distinct from (though related to) the broader suppression of Philippine indigenous religion generally.

Closing

The Banaue rice terraces are a UNESCO World Heritage Site, and they are also, right now, losing ground faster than restoration programs can hold it. The Hudhud epic cycles are inscribed as world intangible heritage, sung by a shrinking number of elders who know the full chant. The babaylan tradition is being actively, publicly rebuilt by contemporary Filipino practitioners and scholars. The mumbaki still names 1,500 deities in the long harvest prayers. The bulul still watches over the granary. The Philippines has more than 180 indigenous nations. This library has barely begun.